



(From left) Siddharth Zarabi, Group Editor of Business Today, with Karnataka's IT & BT minister Priyank Kharge

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'WE LED INDIA'S TECH REVOLUTION'

Priyank Kharge, Karnataka's Minister for Information Technology and Biotechnology, on how the state continues to dominate India's technology and innovation landscape. Edited excerpts:

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On Karnataka's leadership in India's innovation economy

Of about 110 unicorns in the country, more than 47 are based in Karnataka. Over half of India's deep-tech startups are leveraging technology from the state. Around 40% of the country's engineering and research and development talent is from Karnataka, and 38% of semiconductor design comes from here. We are

ranked fifth globally among AI cities and eighth in the global startup ecosystem. In aerospace and defence manufacturing, we contribute 65%. Karnataka has historically been the first mover in policy innovation, laying the groundwork for India's tech revolution. When Karnataka first introduced its IT policy, people mocked it, asking, 'aisi policy se hoga kya? (What will such policies do?). But we led the way—India's first IT policy, biotech policy, startup policy, EV policy, ESDM policy, R&D policy, and even the draft spacetechnology policy came from Karnataka. Others followed our lead.

Despite aggressive competition from other states, Karna-

taka's edge lies in its matured ecosystem. The triple helix of academia, industry, and government took three decades to build. It's not easy to replicate and extremely difficult to beat.

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On the spat between Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh over Google AI data centre in Visakhapatnam

It ultimately benefits India's economy. Now we have Invest Maharashtra, Invest Andhra, Invest Chhattisgarh, even Invest Northeast—and that's good for investors. But there's one thing no one can replicate—our ecosystem. From being a pensioners' paradise, Bengaluru has become one of the world's most disrupt-

tive cities.

We love competition and we thrive on it. Many states have been competing with us for decades, but data speaks for itself. Karnataka recorded IT exports exceeding ₹4.5 lakh crore, while the next closest—Telangana—stood at around ₹2.2 lakh crore.

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On Andhra's ruling TDP coalition and opposition party trading credit for the investments in the state

Despite the political rivalry, Karnataka's long-term strength lies in its ecosystem, talent, and innovation-driven policy framework. Others may compete on subsidies, but we compete on capability.